

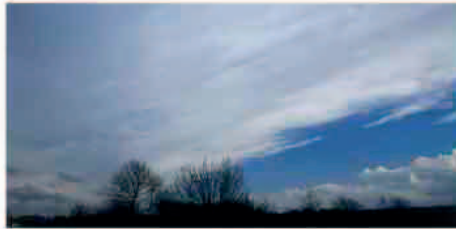
High-level clouds

Cirrus, cirrocumulus, cirrostratus

When water vapor rises to altitudes of 20,000 ft (6,000 m) or more, it condenses into tiny ice crystals. High-level winds often comb the crystals into long, wispy cirrus clouds that look like silver hair. Sometimes, the cloud extends across the sky in a thin sheet of cirrostratus. This is often a sign that bad weather is on the way. Air movements can make this cloud rise and sink in waves, which breaks it up into the small cloudlets of cirrocumulus.



Cirrus



Cirrostratus



Cirrocumulus

Medium-level clouds

Altostratus, altocumulus

The clouds that form at altitudes of 6,500–20,000 ft (2,000–6,000 m) are mostly made of liquid cloud droplets. The extensive flat sheets of altostratus at this level often mark the arrival of a warm front. These can break up into altocumulus, which sometimes forms parallel bands of cloud across the sky. Dark, rainy nimbostratus can sometimes occur at this level as well as nearer to the ground, but it is usually classified as low-level cloud.



Altostratus



Altocumulus

Low-level clouds

Cumulonimbus, cumulus, stratocumulus, stratus, nimbostratus

All clouds that grow below 6,500 ft (2,000 m) are classified as low-level clouds. They include the fluffy cumulus clouds that drift across blue skies in summer and the sheets of gray stratus that spread to the horizon in winter. Cumulus turns into stratocumulus if the clouds merge together. Cumulus can also build higher and higher and turn into colossal cumulonimbus clouds, which rise all the way to the base of the stratosphere. Stratus may thicken into dark, rainy nimbostratus.



Cumulonimbus



Cumulus



Stratocumulus

